



THE INSTITUTE OF
MASTERS
of WINE

Chief Examiner's report

2025 Stage Two MW Exam

The 2025 stage two closed book exam saw stronger results overall, rather than just the headline pass rate. This is a direct result of the careful attention paid by many candidates to what was written in last year's examiners' reports and this is very gratifying for all examiners to see. For those candidates who have yet to reach the pass mark, the contents of our examiners' reports this year provide further insights into how this year's questions were both successfully and unsuccessfully addressed.

My role gives me a holistic viewpoint across all parts of the exam and our candidates' preparation leading up to each of those parts. This year one theme, in particular, has emerged which I can summarise by saying: Be honest with yourself – it's a vital skill in the MW programme. Whether this is deciding if you are ready to sit the stage two closed book exam, or submit your RP for examination, be honest about the state of your preparation. Whether information you are receiving is accurate and reliable; ask yourself if your sources are relevant and representative. Whether you have the required level of understanding needed to attempt a question you choose to answer in the exam; be certain you can answer all parts of the question to the required standard. Whether the wine in front of you really shows the characteristics you are describing; don't be tempted to "shoehorn" – this word comes up more than once in the practical examiners' reports! Have you answered the question in front of you? Don't write an answer to the question you perhaps wish was in front of you – be honest with yourself about what the question is asking for.

But also believe in yourself, acknowledge where you have succeeded and recognise those strengths. Also be honest about where your weaknesses are. The self-reliance necessary to successfully undertake the MW study programme requires that you must be ruthlessly honest with yourself at all points.

We examiners are also mindful of the need to be honest with ourselves, setting questions that are fair and that marking and moderation is accurate. We would very much like to see greater numbers of exam passes, but we also have to be honest with ourselves about which candidates have actually reached the required standard.

Neil Tully MW, Chief Examiner